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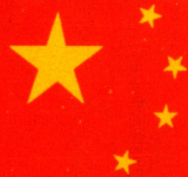


COSTLY AFFAIR:
The main stadium
is an object of
national pride

since 1996. It comes on the back of steep price rise caused by the worst snowstorms in China in five decades, which disrupted the economy. Prices of cooking oil, vegetables and fruits have increased by almost 50 per cent. For millions of poorer Chinese, it's a crushing burden and a serious concern for the country's leadership. The real nightmare for China is that if food prices continue to climb, it could lead to street protests like it did in the mid-'90s, a scenario China would desperately like to avoid in the Olympic year.

Then there is the problem caused by a consumerist society. Scammers, hustlers and prostitutes throng places of visitor interest, including Tiananmen Square, where Mao's body lies. The Great Helmsman is now reduced to a face on a T-shirt or a bust in shops selling tourist nick-knacks. In Tiananmen Square, late at night, prostitutes and pimps bargain for glimpses of a Forbidden City (not the one across the road). Crime is a growing worry. Last week, additional Special Police were sent to Guangzhou to "crack down on robbery, organised crime, burglary and prostitution".

Aspiration, envy and capitalistic greed are creating a culture which is detrimental to China's image as a disciplined society. The designer stores, malls, restaurants and fast food outlets in the more affluent areas symbolise



Vegetable prices in China have risen by almost 50 per cent. If this continues, it could lead to civil unrest.



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China's economic miracle but also its obsession with the West. That is reflected in their names. It's quite a culture shock to meet men and women with first names like Larry or Sandra, much like the Hong Kong Chinese. Our translator asked us to call him "Ed".

Despite that, a serious problem that China will face during the Olympics is communication. It's tough to find a Chinese who speaks passable English, even in hotels and among taxi drivers. They really don't care. It's an attitude that could cost them a lot of goodwill during the Games, and goodwill is something the Chinese are

desperately short of right now.

The Chinese revel in symbolism, of which there is plenty to be found. In Beijing, the main Olympic stadium is an outrageous ensemble of woven steel beams meant to resemble a giant bird's nest, but it also looks incredibly fragile. According to popular belief, *weiji*, the Chinese word for 'crisis', means both danger and opportunity. The Olympics, for China's leadership, represent both in equal measure. Right now, however, the Olympic clock in Tiananmen Square counting down to opening day has started acquiring an ominous-sounding ring. ■